Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations

International Trade Centre

Making the African Continental Free Trade Area work for women

Gender-inclusive toolkit for financial institutions in sub-Saharan Africa

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About the paper

The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) and the International Trade Centre (ITC) have joined efforts to support women in overcoming gender-based obstacles in the context of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) agreement. The Empowering women and boosting livelihoods through agricultural trade: Leveraging the AfCFTA (EWAT) programme was developed in 2021 with the objective of promoting women's participation in the AfCFTA, and increasing their access to capacity building and higher-productivity activities, capitalizing on the new opportunities in regional trade created by the AfCFTA agreement.

One of the main constraints women continue to face is access to finance. Not only is agriculture traditionally associated with lower returns and high-risk investments for financiers, but women are also unconsciously perceived to be a riskier segment. Factors include discriminatory social and gender norms and biases that affect capital providers' perception of women as well as women's financial literacy, bookkeeping skills and investment readiness. Lack of collateral is a major constraint, largely due to women's limited ownership and control over land in the African context.

The objective of this toolkit is to raise awareness of the business case for financing women in agricultural value chains and to provide financial institutions with practical guidance for advancing gender-inclusive strategies across different parts of their organizations. This toolkit is complementary to the policy brief developed under the same FAO–ITC EWAT programme – 'Facilitating gender-responsive access to finance in the agrifood sector in Sub-Saharan Africa: Making the African Continental Free Trade Area work for women'. Building on case studies from the Ghanaian and Nigerian contexts, the policy brief provides concrete recommendations for financiers and other relevant stakeholders in the agrifinancing ecosystem to foster gender-responsive financing.

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Abbreviations

AfCFTA	African Continental Free Trade Area
AVC	agricultural value chain
DFS	digital financial services
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
ISO	International Organization for Standardization
ITC	International Trade Centre
MFI	microfinance institution
MSME	micro, small and medium-sized enterprise
NPL	non-performing loan
SACCO	savings and credit cooperative
SME	small and medium-sized enterprise

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CONTENTS

METHODOLOGY

Multiple resources for addressing gender inclusivity exist across various sectors. In the financial sector, these resources have been further customized for diverse actors such as development institutions, financial institutions, private equity institutions, venture capital firms and angel investors. This toolkit aims to contribute to the growing body of gender toolkits developed specifically for financial institutions, with consideration of the nuances in the agricultural sector in sub-Saharan Africa.

The approach followed in this toolkit has been informed by a review of existing literature. To address gaps in existing literature, this toolkit places more focus on resources that can support financial institutions to develop financial products and outreach strategies to reach more women in agricultural value chains (AVCs).

The toolkit presents a collection of resources that financial institutions can use to advance gender inclusivity across the organization. Presentation of resources is designed to help financial institutions understand the purpose of the resource, readily digest key requirements and demystify perceptions of complexity to encourage practical action to advance gender inclusivity.

This approach was extended to the Gender Inclusivity Self-Appraisal Tool to be used in conjunction with this toolkit. This complementary tool was developed by ITC and FAO to help financial institutions understand their level of maturity in relation to gender inclusivity.

HOW TO USE THIS TOOLKIT

Target audience

The target audience for this toolkit is financial institutions in sub-Saharan Africa. That is, financial service providers that offer financing products such as payments, savings, credit, insurance and investment on commercial terms. The term “financial institution” is extremely broad and encompasses retail and commercial banks, savings and credit cooperatives (SACCOs), microfinance institutions (MFIs) and digital financial services (DFS).

The toolkit specifically targets financial institutions with a low level of maturity in relation to gender inclusivity. This corresponds to institutions that either (i) are not aware of the gender gaps in agrifinance and the business case; or (ii) are aware and have the intention to adapt their activities to reduce gender barriers and better meet the financial needs of women in AVCs in sub-Saharan Africa.

A report on SACCOs in Kenya indicated that women are underrepresented in SACCOs, with a membership rate of 34 percent (SASRA, 2019). Research on DFS (Varangis *et al.*, 2021) found that women farmers may need different digital financial products and outreach strategies compared to men. Although women are overrepresented in MFIs, MFI products are targeted at the most disadvantaged and may not be a match for the various roles women perform, including in AVCs (Varangis *et al.*, 2021).

Using the toolkit

This toolkit should be used in conjunction with the Gender Inclusivity Self Appraisal Tool. The self-appraisal tool is designed to help financial institutions evaluate how they perform across the three toolkit components (see Chapter 3), prioritize areas for action and identify resources from the toolkit that can be used to advance gender-inclusive strategies.

The toolkit provides a collection of frameworks, guidance and checklists with tips and examples to help financial institutions become more gender-inclusive. The resources are non-sequential and each resource includes:

- the objective of the resource to help financial institutions quickly identify if the resource addresses their specific needs
- key steps/requirements and, in most cases, a snapshot to help demystify perceptions of complexity
- links to resources

Disclaimer:
The resources presented are to be used as a guide and are not intended to be interpreted as exhaustive.

FAO and/or ITC are not responsible for the currency, accuracy or legality of content from external links.

When to use the toolkit

WOULD THE FINANCIAL INSTITUTION LIKE TO LEARN MORE ABOUT GENDER INCLUSIVITY?

- YES → Great! You are in the right place.
- NO → Share this resource with your networks

WOULD THE FINANCIAL INSTITUTION LIKE TO EVALUATE ITS LEVEL OF GENDER INCLUSIVITY AND IDENTIFY PRIORITY ACTIONS TO ADDRESS GENDER GAPS?

- YES → Use the FAO–ITC Gender Inclusivity Self Appraisal Tool. The tool will recommend resources from the toolkit that the financial institution can use to get started.
- NO → No, it is clear what the financial institution needs to work on. → Use this toolkit for recommendations of resources the financial institution can use to address gender inclusivity gaps across the internal environment, financial products and outreach and monitoring and evaluation (Chapter 3).

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CHAPTER 1: FINANCING FOR WOMEN IN AGRICULTURAL VALUE CHAINS: CHALLENGES AND BUILDING THE BUSINESS CASE

IN AFRICA, 85 percent of economic activity is conducted informally, where women provide 90 percent of the labour force (FAO, 2021). Women account for nearly 70 percent of informal cross-border traders in Africa (UNDP, 2020). Women are also prevalent among owners of micro, small and medium-sized enterprises (MSMEs). As such, women are more vulnerable to economic shocks caused by market disruptions (FAO, 2021).

Women in agricultural value chains

Women play critical roles in agrifood systems and AVCs, including as producers, traders, processors and agribusiness owners. In sub-Saharan Africa, agrifood systems account for 66 percent of women's employment compared with 60 percent for men (FAO, 2023a). To ensure that implementation of the AfCFTA is fair and inclusive, women must be supported to overcome gender barriers to have an active role in increasingly formal markets and value chains (FAO, 2021).

From a financing perspective, agrifinancing in sub-Saharan Africa is associated with higher risk due to weather vulnerabilities related to an over-reliance on rainfed agriculture, commodity price fluctuations and moral hazards[1] associated with smallholder farming (Absa, 2024). Against this background, financing challenges for women in AVCs are exacerbated by gender barriers.

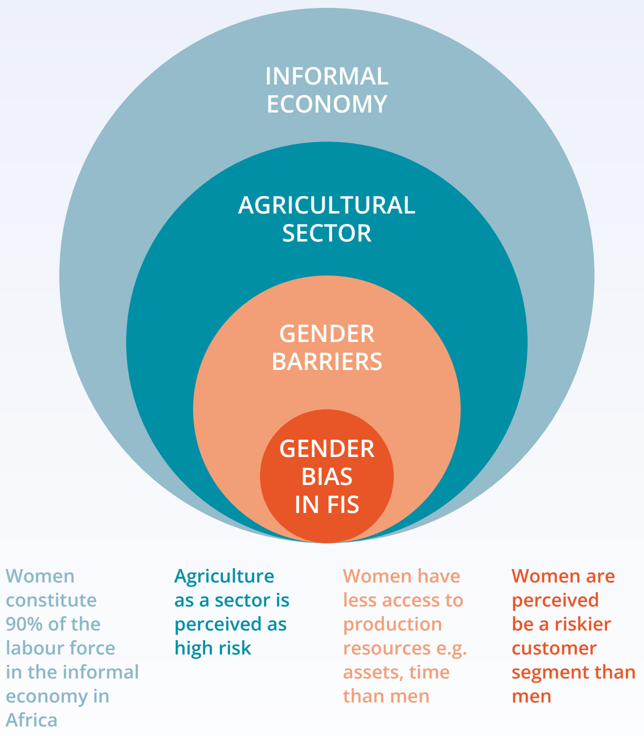
Gender barriers restricting access to finance for women in agricultural value chains

The policy brief complementing this toolkit details some of the causes of the barriers that restrict access to finance for women in AVCs in sub-Saharan Africa (FAO and ITC, 2024). Some result from restrictive social and gender norms that exclude women from land ownership, access to extension services and education. This may have a negative impact on how society views women's roles, including their capacity to run a business. The business skills and financial literacy levels of women entrepreneurs are also lower compared to men. Women spend less time in their businesses because of household duties and their enterprises are largely informal and lack assets that can be used as collateral (FAO, 2023b). Women entrepreneurs are also risk-averse and financial products fail to match their needs. Financing costs are high and women entrepreneurs lack access to guarantee and insurance schemes to reduce perceived risks for financiers (FAO and ITC, 2024).

Challenges for financial institutions

The agricultural SME finance gap in sub-Saharan Africa and Asia (excluding India) is estimated at USD 106 billion (ISF Advisors, 2022). In sub-Saharan Africa, only 25 percent of the estimated USD 240 billion agrifinance demand is met (Aceli Africa, 2020). For women entrepreneurs across Africa, the financing gap is estimated at USD 42 billion (AfDB, 2023).

Figure 1: Financing challenges associated with women in agricultural value chains



SOURCE: Devised by author.

Financial institutions face challenges in financing women in AVCs. A strong business case is demanded to invest in this category, which is perceived to have a higher level of risk and high transaction costs. Sub-Saharan Africa lacks a rich body of data – particularly gender and sex-disaggregated data – demonstrating the business case for investing in women-owned and women-led agrifood MSMEs.

Many financial institutions lack access to gender and agriculture experts to understand constraints for women and men in the agrifood sector and to advise on women's financing needs and risks. As a result, financial products are sometimes not fit for purpose and involve burdensome application requirements such as collateral. Some of the smaller institutions like SACCOs, MFIs and DFS may lack diversity in teams further curtailing gender inclusivity in financial products.

Women entrepreneurs often need non-financial services to be credit ready and these may not be

1. Moral hazards encompass unfavourable farmer behaviour such as side selling where there is an off-taking contract in place.

included in the customer value proposition offered by financial institutions with lower levels of gender inclusivity. Even where gender-inclusive products exist, institutions may not use gender-smart outreach strategies resulting in a low uptake of financial products.[2]

The business case for financing women in agricultural value chains

A body of evidence is emerging to demonstrate the business case for financing women in AVCs (GIZ, 2023). IFC Banking on Women (2019) reported that, for four consecutive years, loan portfolios for women-led small and medium-sized enterprise (SMEs) performed better than total loan portfolios inclusive of men. In 2018, the average NPL ratio for women-led SMEs was 3 percent, in contrast to a ratio of 4.9 percent for total loan portfolios. Root Capital (2022) also found that women-owned and women-led agricultural enterprises grow faster and are less likely to see fluctuations in revenues. They also contribute less to NPLs and generate higher returns than businesses that are less gender-inclusive.

With the same access to finance as men, women in AVCs could increase agricultural yields and strengthen food security (FAO, 2021). Reducing the gender gap in global agrifood systems would increase gross domestic product by 1 percent (or nearly USD 1 trillion), reduce global food insecurity by about 2 percentage points and reduce the number of food-insecure people by 45 million (FAO, 2023a).

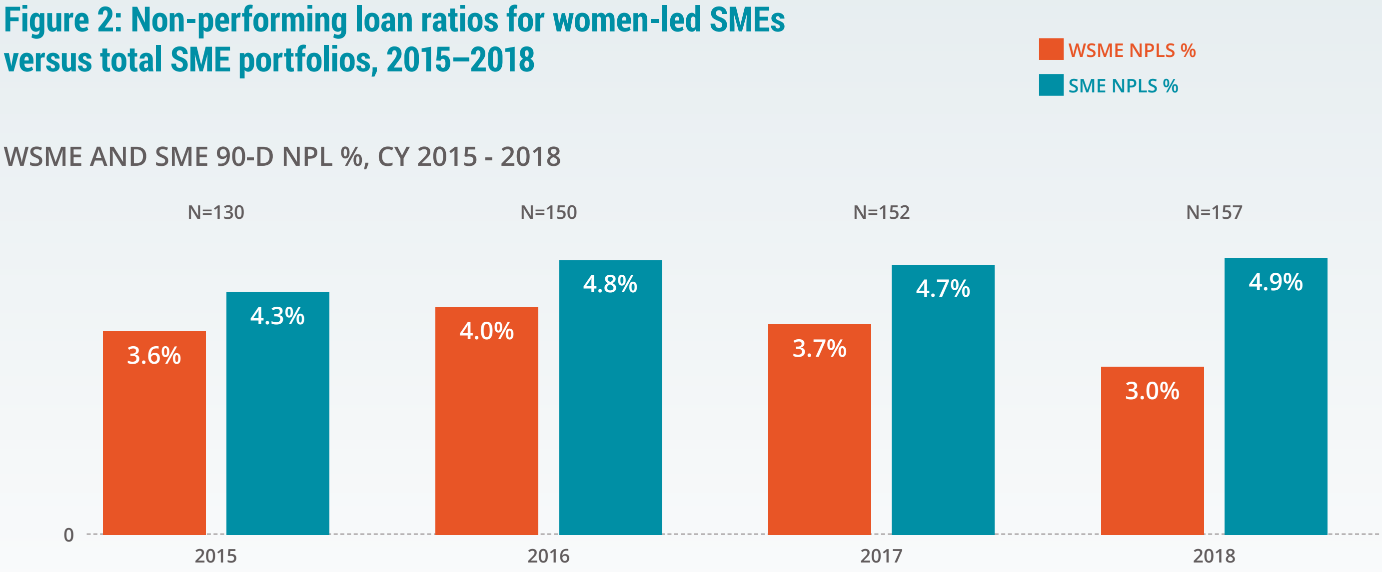
Financing opportunities for women in agricultural value chains

Larger regional financial institutions such as EcoBank and Absa Bank have developed value chain and insurance approaches to address risks associated with agrifinancing. Against these products, these institutions have then been able to extend the customer value propositions specifically created for women with features such as extended payment tenors, higher withdrawal limits, lower thresholds for applications, 30-day fees-based loans and lower interest rates. Features also include non-financial services such as training on business registration and tax compliance, accounting and succession.

A concept that is gaining popularity in unlocking finance for underserved communities, including women in AVCs, is blended finance. Blended

2. Roundtable meeting discussions in Accra, Ghana and Lagos, Nigeria in 2023

Figure 2: Non-performing loan ratios for women-led SMEs versus total SME portfolios, 2015–2018



SOURCE: IFC. 2019. *Business Case Update Number Two: Lower NPLs for women-led SMEs.* IFC Banking on Women Brief. Washington, D.C.

finance refers to the strategic use of philanthropic and public capital to catalyse investment by the private sector seeking commercial returns (Value for Women, 2023).

Combining different sources of funding, each with its own risk-return profile, blended financing catalyses investments that might not otherwise be feasible or attractive to private investors alone. This approach aims to leverage the strengths of both public and private sectors to address global challenges such as poverty alleviation, infrastructure development, climate change mitigation, and sustainable development.

Examples of successful blended finance projects benefiting rural women include initiatives supporting women-led agricultural cooperatives in countries like Kenya, Rwanda and Uganda, which have improved women's access to finance, markets and agricultural inputs, leading to increased productivity, incomes and return on investment.

A study by Root Capital (2022) found that gender-inclusive enterprises were 20 percent more likely to obtain new impact or commercial capital after having been financed exclusively by Root Capital. This suggests that investments in women in AVCs can accelerate access to new sources of finance for these women. In 2022, 25 percent of blended finance structures (USD 191 million) committed to addressing gender gaps were in agriculture (OECD, 2022).

For financial institutions, this means that blended finance should be considered in developing gender policies and in selecting partners to improve financial products and outreach strategies.

Recommendations for financial institutions

Adopting gender-inclusive approaches in agrifinancing can unlock opportunities for financial institutions for higher returns, growth and sustainability. To ensure greater access to finance for women across the whole value chain, these approaches must consider the diverse roles and respective financial needs of women in AVCs and the specific challenges faced.

Financial institutions can increase access to finance for women in AVCs through tailored financial offerings and delivery channels that address the constraints faced by women in the agrifood sector. These include:

- adoption of digital technology
- microfinance and community banking
- credit guarantees and insurance
- advisory and capacity development assistance
- financing approaches alternative to collateral, lowering the cost of loans and interest rates
- blended finance.

CHAPTER 2: DECODING WOMEN'S ROLES IN AGRICULTURAL VALUE CHAINS AND RESPECTIVE FINANCIAL NEEDS

THE NEEDS OF WOMEN in AVCs can be categorized according to their role in the value chain. Most women involved in agrifood value chains in sub-Saharan African may play various roles at the same time: producers, processors, traders and agribusiness owners/managers (FAO, 2016, 2014; FAO and ITC, 2024). Within these roles women in AVCs have different financial needs ranging from working capital to asset financing.

Profiles and potential financial needs

Producers

Women involved in primary agriculture production sometimes also participate in the sale of small volumes of agricultural commodities across different value chains. Producers are largely smallholder farmers but could also work in mid- and large-scale farms. These producers are often characterized by low levels of literacy, informal operations, a lack of access to production resources and lack of market information. In many sub-Saharan African countries, women do not own the land on which they produce because land is often registered in the name of a male relative. Many smallholder farmers may not be banked through traditional banks but through SACCOs and DFS.

Financial needs may include:

- transactions (payments, receipts and withdrawals)
- input financing
- insurance and working capital (e.g. for farmhands)
- asset financing (e.g. for irrigation equipment).

Processors

Women involved in processing activities purchase and aggregate agricultural commodities add some basic value through activities such as sorting, grading and packaging. The women have access to basic processing facilities and are characterized by higher levels of business and financial literacy than producers and some may have access to markets. In many cases, the women operate informally and may also have their own farms for primary production.

Financial needs may include:

- transactions
- input financing
- insurance
- working capital (e.g. for inventory)
- asset financing (e.g. for cutting and packaging equipment)
- capital for expansion.

Traders

Women traders are involved in the buying and selling of raw and processed agricultural commodities to other intermediaries such as aggregators, wholesalers and retailers. These are often referred to as 'brokers'. Women traders have higher levels of business literacy, often having honed their skills from others in the trade. They could be small or large scale depending on the volumes they turn over. Traders may also be involved in production, processing and aggregation, and can also sell directly to the market. Gender norms and roles may restrict the participation of women trader in higher-value activities. For example, women are less likely to participate in transportation activities because women are expected to stay close to home tending to farms and household duties, whereas men have greater freedom to travel further for trading activities.

Financial needs may include:

- transactions
- insurance
- working capital (e.g. for inventory)
- asset financing (e.g. for storage and transportation assets)
- capital for expansion.

Agribusiness owners/managers

Women involved in agribusiness add value to agricultural commodities to increase shelf life or develop new products. They have high levels of business and financial literacy, access to processing/manufacturing equipment and facilities, and improved access to finance and markets. Women in agribusiness may also have their own farms to supplement supplies purchased from smallholder farmers/and or traders. They also generate the highest profit margins in the value chain. Women's participation in agribusiness may be restricted by gender norms that limit women to primary production and/or basic processing activities. Participation may also be curtailed by limited access to business skills and assets.

Financial needs may include:

- transactions
- insurance
- working capital
- asset financing (e.g. for processing/manufacturing assets)
- capital for expansion or investment options.

CHAPTER 3: DEVELOPING GENDER-INCLUSIVE FINANCIAL SERVICES

GENDER INCLUSIVITY STRATEGIES work best within institutions that demonstrate a commitment to ensuring that women-owned and women-led businesses as a market are not excluded or underserved. Diverse approaches in serving the market also require that diversity is reflected within the institution itself, including having women in leadership and the workforce. Staff also need to be sensitized to gender dynamics, including social and gender biases. Financial products and services likely also need to be redesigned to be accessible, affordable and consumable for women. Barriers to these elements should be understood and addressed. Institutions are also likely to need to adapt marketing methods, messages and channels to reach more women.

This toolkit therefore considers gender inclusivity in financial institutions across three main components: internal environment; financial products and outreach; and monitoring and evaluation. Figure 3 provides a summary of the key purpose of each component and a list of associated tools.

The target audience for the toolkit is financial institutions specifically. Many resources already exist that cover the areas included in the internal environment and monitoring and reporting components. This toolkit therefore places more focus on the financial products and outreach component, with the addition of examples from practice.

Figure 3: Toolkit components, key purpose and associated tools

Internal environment

Integrating gender into policies and strategies of financial institutions and aligning leadership and the workforce

Financial products and outreach

Integrating a gender lens in product design and marketing campaigns

Monitoring and evaluation

How to track and report on gender inclusivity performance

Tools

Internal environment:

1. Gender Policy Development Guidance
2. Business Case Development Tool
3. Gender-Responsive Business Model Canvas
4. Gender Diversity Toolkit

Financial products and outreach:

1. Gender Integration Guide
2. Gender-Inclusive Product Design Checklist
3. Gender Segmentation Exercise
4. Gender-Inclusive Customer Journey Mapping
5. Gender Lens Marketing Guidance
6. Partner Selection Tool

Monitoring and evaluation:

1. Gender Monitoring and Evaluation Framework
2. Sample Gender Key Performance Indicators
3. Gender-Disaggregated Data Guidance

SOURCE: Devised by author.

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1. Gender policy development guidance

Objective: This checklist can help financial institutions to have a better understanding of the essential concepts of a gender-inclusive policy and to develop appropriate courses of action for either establishing new policies or reviewing existing policies.

Key steps

1. Develop a coordination mechanism to lead the process (e.g. focal points or working groups).
2. Conduct a baseline for gender sensitivity within the institution.
3. Build team capacity on gender sensitivity and the business case.
4. Take stock of existing policies and review with a gender lens.
5. Set priorities to address gaps and develop an action plan.
6. Develop a monitoring and evaluation framework that will underpin periodic progress reviews.

Resources

- Toolkit On Gender Inclusive Policy Development (Alliance for Financial Inclusion)
- Gender Action Plan Template (Annex 1)

Figure 4: Sample questions for a gender lens review of policy

Questions to ask during a gender lens review

- Does this policy treat everyone in the same way?
- Does it consider the power dynamics and imbalances between men and women and girls and boys?
- Does it consider the different roles, rights, and responsibilities men and women have in society and underlying implications?
- Will women be able to benefit from this policy in the same way as men?
- What work has already been done to understand the different women's markets, and what more must be done to understand their needs?
- Is the M&E policy designed in such a way that it understands the needs and experiences of different genders?

SOURCE: AFI. 2022. *Toolkit on Gender Inclusive Policy Development.* Kuala Lumpur.

2. Business case development tool

Objective: This tool is designed to help financial institutions quantify the opportunity in the women's market to present the case to get management buy-in. Even with sustainability and inclusivity considerations gaining popularity, financial institutions still require attractive returns to invest in traditionally underserved markets.

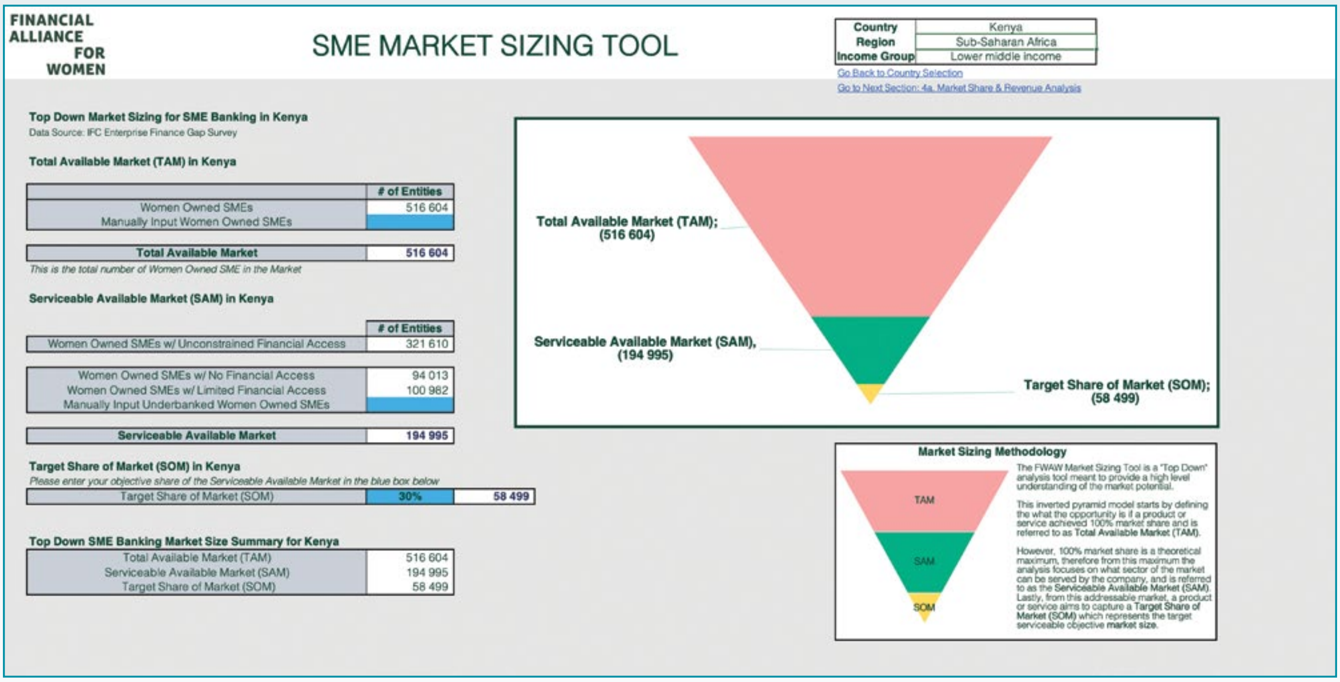
Key steps

1. Analyse how the financial institution is currently serving women compared to men to uncover gaps in service provision. This involves collecting gender-disaggregated data.
2. Research the women's market to identify target segment(s) to serve.
3. Conduct market sizing to quantify existing opportunities.
4. Project financial returns from new or additional investment in the women's market.
5. Develop a pitch deck that collates all the information together to present to management to obtain buy-in.

Resources

- Global Business Case Tool for Financial Services Providers (Financial Alliance for Women)
- Guidance on gender-disaggregated data in monitoring and reporting (Section 3.3)

Figure 5: Sample SME market sizing tool



SOURCE: Financial Alliance for Women. 2019. *Global Business Case Tool for Financial Services Providers.* New York. https://financialallianceforwomen.org/business-case-tool/#:~:text=This%20tool%20aggregates%20the%20latest,business%20case%20for%20targeting%20women

3. Gender-responsive Business Model Canvas

Objective: This canvas enables a financial institution to re-examine its business model from a gender perspective and to identify opportunities to close gender gaps across its entire operation.

Key requirement

Complete the various segments of the Business Model Canvas.

Resources

- The gender-responsive Business Model Canvas: A tool to assess agricultural service provision from a gender perspective (FAO)
- Business Model Canvas template (Annex 2)
- Business Model Canvas sample guiding questions (Annex 3)

Tips to consider for incorporating a gender perspective

- *Is the product **relevant** for women? Does it respond to women's needs? Is it efficient? Are there other benefits?*
- *Is the product **available** to women? When and where does their need arise? Is it in a consumable form?*
- *Can women **access** the product? Is the product accessible to women in person? Are there alternative methods to access the product (delivery, virtual, mobile etc.)?*
- *Is it **affordable** to women? Are women willing to pay for it?*

4. Gender diversity toolkit

Objective: This toolkit helps financial institutions to evaluate its workforce from a gender perspective, understand existing gender gaps in diversity and explore opportunities to increase the participation of women at all staff levels.

Key steps

1. Define the organizational staff levels (e.g. Board member, executive, manager, operative) and collect gender-disaggregated data.
2. Analyse the data to assess gender issues within the institution and to identify challenges and recommendations to improve inclusivity.
3. Identify key priority areas, set targets and develop an action plan.
4. Develop a communication plan to share the business case with stakeholders to promote cooperation.
5. Monitor and evaluate progress periodically.

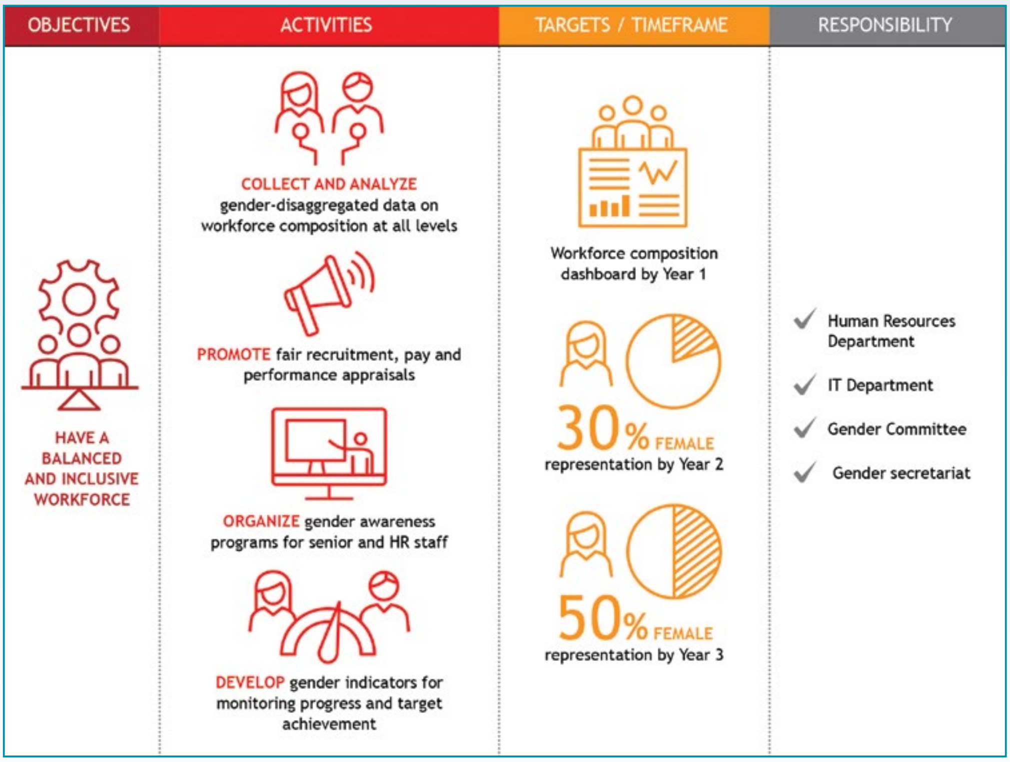
Resources

- A Toolkit for Increasing Gender Diversity and Women's Leadership in Financial Regulatory Institutions (Alliance for Financial Inclusion)
- Gender Action Plan template (Annex 1)
- Gender-Inclusive Workplace Guidance Note in Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling Financial Institutions to Mainstream Gender-Smart Solutions in Their Green Finance Operations (Inter-American Development Bank)

Additional material

- Gender Diversity Toolkit (British International Investment)

Figure 6: Sample action plan for a balanced and inclusive workforce



SOURCE: AFI. 2023. *A Toolkit for Increasing Gender Diversity and Women's Leadership in Financial Regulatory Institutions.* Kuala Lumpur. https://www.afi-global.org/publications/a-toolkit-for-increasing-gender-diversity-and-womens-leadership-in-financial-regulatory-institutions/

Financial products and outreach

1. Gender integration guide

Objective: To help financial institutions start to integrate a gender perspective in the product design process, by understanding how gender affects access to finance for women customers, and developing gender-inclusive solutions.

Key considerations

Problem	• Has the problem been clearly defined?
Population	• How does the problem affect women differently based on their demographics (age, education, income, etc.)? • What demographic do we want to serve? Why? • How would that demographic benefit?
Gender constraints and context	• Have the barriers and challenges faced by women been clearly identified? • How does the social context affect these barriers and challenges? • How may our institutional policies and practices affect these barriers and challenges?
Solution	• In developing a proposed solution, how were the gender gaps prioritized? • Is there a clear plan of how the proposed solution will address the prioritized gender gaps? • Have the benefits been defined clearly for the selected demographic? • Has there been an analysis of the potential risks associated with the proposed solution? • How can men be engaged in the solution? • Does it align with the outcomes and outputs in the results framework (see more in Section 3.3)

Resources

- Gender integration guide in Gender Transformative Toolkit (Mercy Corps AgriFin)

2. Gender-inclusive product design checklist

Objective: To help financial institutions to develop products that are relevant, available, accessible and affordable to women customers by integrating women through the product design process.

Key considerations

1. Product strategy	2. Product design	3. Product eligibility and terms	4. Product uptake
• Are women's needs/ behaviours/barriers understood? • Have partnerships been identified to increase access for women?	• Are women involved, or at least consulted, throughout the process? • Is reliable data on women taken into account?	• Do lending requirements unconsciously exclude women? • Can women provide security required such as assets for a loan? • Can alternative collateral be used? • Are credit tenures and repayment structures inclusive of women? • Are interest rates affordable to women?	• Can women access information about the product e.g. in person or online? • Do women have ease of access to the product e.g. in person or online? • Can women easily provide product feedback?

Resources

- Gender-Inclusive Green Loan Design Checklist in Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling Financial Institutions to Mainstream Gender-Smart Solutions in Their Green Finance Operations (Inter-American Development Bank)

Box 1: Example in practice: Ecobank Ellevate Programme

Ellevate from Ecobank in Ghana

Ecobank is a pan-African banking institution with operations in 33 African countries. It is the leading independent regional banking group in West and Central Africa, serving wholesale and retail customers. Ecobank Ghana has been in operation since 1990 and had a balance sheet size of over USD 2 billion at the end of 2022. It has 65 branches, 248 ATMs, over 3 900 Xpress Points (agency outlets) and online and mobile banking solutions. In 2020, Ecobank started to roll out its Ellevate Programme for women-owned and women-led businesses. For Ecobank, women-owned and women-led businesses must meet one of the following criteria: at least 51 percent owned by women; any business being managed by women; at least 30 percent or more employees are women; or manufactures products for women.

Product design considerations:

1. Product strategy:

Ecobank is conversant with the barriers that limit access finance for women in agricultural value chains. To address risks associated with lending to women producers and processors, Ecobank adopts a value chain financing perspective. This enables the bank to leverage partnerships with less risky entities in the value chain – such as buyers like Unilever – who then onboard their suppliers and distributors.

2. Product design:

In developing Ellevate, Ecobank used existing data to support the business case for investing in women and consulted various stakeholder such as risk teams to address several of the existing financing challenges for women.

3. Product eligibility and terms:

Ellevate embodies the following features to increase access to finance for women, including women in agricultural value chains:

- Cash flow-based 30-day lending that does not require collateral
- Inventory and asset financing that uses inventory/asset as collateral
- Daily and weekly credit repayments that align with the cashflow cycles of women's businesses
- Fee-based lending products that are more attractive to women than interest rates
- Lower interest rates between 0.5 and 2.5 percentage points on other financing categories such as asset finance
- Digital solutions to develop a successful online presence with a Google My Business profile – a free tool to help businesses attract and engage customers who carry out Google searches, with links to the search, map listings, photos, offers, messages and reviews.
- Networking opportunities with peers find new business opportunities, and learn how to get the best deals for financing your business growth.
- Non-financial services that include training (e.g. on accounting and succession or access to market information)

4. Product uptake:

ellevate by Ecobank

Ellevate features an in-branch women's desk where women can make enquiries and give feedback, and mobile or online digital banking that is accessible anywhere anytime. Ecobank is working on an insurance and savings proposition.

SOURCE: **Ecobank in Ghana**. n.d. *Ecobank*. Cited 21 May 2024. https://ecobank.com/gh/personal-banking/countries;
Ellevate by Ecobank. n.d. *Ecobank*. Cited 21 May 2024. https://www.ecobank.com/commercial-banking/ellevate

3. Gender segmentation exercise

Objective: To help financial institutions better serve women in agricultural value chains through increased understanding of their financial needs and behaviours.

Key steps

1. Define possible customer segments based on key activities (see Chapter 2)
2. Conduct market sizing for each segment to determine markets and prioritize which segments to serve.
3. Research demographic characteristics such as age, income, education and geography for each prioritized segment and analyse inferences on financial behaviour and needs. Validate inferences with primary research such as surveys and focus groups.
4. Ideate on opportunities to address unmet needs, improve efficiency and introduce additional benefits.
5. Evaluate investment risk and mitigation measures.

Tip

Existing customer segmentations of women in agricultural value chains in Africa can be used as a starting point for building on the segmentation exercise.

One example from Kenya and Zambia is persona libraries of women farmers that were developed based on extensive and robust research on what drives financial behaviours (Mercy Corps AgriFin, 2021)

Resources

- Gender Segmentation Exercise (Annex 4)
- Demographics Analysis and Market Sizing Tool in Global Business Case Tool for Financial Services Providers (Financial Alliance for Women)
- Gender-inclusive persona profile in Gender Transformative Toolkit (Mercy Corps AgriFin)

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Box 2: Example in practice: Absa She Business Account

She Business Account from Absa Bank Kenya

Absa Group Limited is one of Africa's largest diversified financial services providers with a presence in 12 countries. Absa Bank Kenya PLC (formerly Barclays Bank Kenya Limited) has been in operation for over 100 years, with 85 branches, over 210 ATMs and internet and mobile banking channels. Absa's Women in Business Proposition focuses on supporting women entrepreneurs and enterprises through financing, advisory, capacity building, networking and access to markets. Agriculture is also a key sector for Absa and currently constitutes 12 percent of its business, with Absa currently ranked fourth in the Agribusiness space in Kenya.

Customer segmentation

Absa has a fully-fledged Agribusiness division with key capacities with Head of Agribusiness, dedicated Relationship Managers, Credit Analyst, Product Specialist, and an Agribusiness Specialist. The Bank has adopted a value chain approach solutioning end to end for both credit and transactional capabilities. Key value chains include tea, dairy, horticulture (flori), cereals and pulses, livestock, coffee, input providers among other.

While scaling up its activities in the agricultural sector, Absa surveyed its customer portfolio to determine their key needs. While male customers prioritized access to finance, women customers prioritized non-financial services that include access to markets, access to information and coaching & mentorship. Absa has also assessed the financial risk associated with various roles in the value chain. As such, Absa extends its Agri financing products primarily to post-production activities, integrating a value chain financing perspective.

Absa continues to keep pulse of the needs of its women customers and adjusts products to match their requirements, especially in the Agribusiness space. For example, within its non-financial services products, Absa has introduced a tax training module led by an expert to support women customers with tax compliance, an area that remains a key barrier to financing. In the past, the Bank has also partnered with industry players in dairy, cereals and horticulture to empower smallholder farmers on best practices to manage post-harvest losses.

absa

Absa Bank Kenya is also the host institution of the SheTrades Kenya Hub.

SOURCES: **Absa Bank Kenya.** Meeting with ITC and FAO. Nairobi, 25 January 2024; **Absa Bank Kenya**. 2024. *About Absa Bank Kenya PLC*. Cited 25 January 2024. https://www.absabank.co.ke/about-us/

4. Gender customer journey mapping

Objective: To help financial institutions to map the experience of women customers as they engage with its product(s) and to understand existing gaps and challenges across the entire customer journey. The gaps and challenges provide a basis to enhance the product and/or experience. For women in agricultural value chains, an institution may map the customer journey with the help of existing customers.

Customer experiences should ideally be mapped for each customer segment (e.g. producers, traders, processors and agribusinesses) and further compared between men and women to clearly distinguish what women value towards improving the women's value proposition. The worksheet can also be completed with target customers for a new product.

Key steps

1. Select the customer segment(s) for the mapping (see Gender Segmentation Exercise).
2. Map out the key touch points for customers and incorporate a gender lens to define the customer experience at each stage.
3. Analyse findings and use this an opportunity to improve the product.
4. Test the improved product with a customer sample.

Resources

- Gender-inclusive customer journey worksheet in Gender Transformative Toolkit (Mercy Corps AgriFin)

Additional resources

- Gender-Responsive Market Research Guidance Note in Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling Financial Institutions to Mainstream Gender-Smart Solutions in Their Green Finance Operations (Inter-American Development Bank)

Tip

The customer journey mapping can also generate new insights if done with a sample of existing or target customers and if resources allow.

Customer experiences can also be collected through surveys (see the Gender-Responsive Market Research Guidance Note on creating surveys).

Figure 7: Sample gender-inclusive customer journey worksheet

Go through the below template to familiarize yourself with the various stages of a customer journey and refer to the specific prompts under each section which will help you apply a gender lens. You can modify these stages as per your needs.

PERSONA NAME:
(Use a persona you have identified from research)

JOURNEY NAME:
(Define the journey you want to improve)

STAGES	AWARENESS	EVALUATION	ACQUISITION	RETENTION	ADVOCACY
List all stages chronologically from awareness to repeat use	Customer finds out about the product / service	Customer assesses whether to use the product / service or not	Customer uses the product or service	Customer is a repeat user	Customer encourages others to use the product / service

TOUCHPOINT

Describe the actions your persona takes at each stage to interact with your product

* What activities does the woman need to undertake to interact with your product or service?
* What are the social norms or gender norms that impact various touchpoints?

PRODUCT EXPERIENCE

What feelings to these actions evoke in the persona? (Use one of these emojis to describe feelings)

KEY FEATURES

Define the main product features the persona interacts with across stages

* Which features do women enjoy & use comfortably?
* Which features frustrate women?

CHANNELS

What channels does the persona use to access the product or service

* Which channels do women use more and which do they prefer? Why?
* Which are a barrier to access and continued use?

PAIN POINTS

Describe the problems they run into as they use the product or service

* What barriers do women face as they interact with your product?
* What social norms and barriers do women face as they interact with your product?
* Do women have misconceptions about your product or service? Why?

OPPORTUNITY

How can you address these pain points

* What interventions can be designed to address this woman's pain points?
* What new features, messages, products and services can be introduced to address pain points?
* Are there opportunities to address barriers from social norms?

* Prompts to help you apply a gender lens during this exercise

SOURCE: Mercy Corps AgriFin. 2021. *Gender Transformative Toolkit*. Nairobi. https://www.mercycorpsagrifin.org/agrifin-gender-transformative-toolkit/

5. Gender lens marketing guidance

Objective: To help financial institutions identify the right marketing channels and design marketing messages that reach more women in agricultural value chains.

Key steps

1. Examine marketing assets for gender inclusivity and source new ones if required.
2. Evaluate marketing messages for stereotypes and realism and adapt as necessary.
3. Evaluate marketing channels used to reach women across different segments for unintended biases and adjust as needed.
4. Build diverse marketing teams or at a minimum consult women.
5. Leverage insights that may be gathered from customer feedback.

Resources

- InBrief: Gender-Lens Marketing: Driving Lasting Change by Championing Women (Financing Alliance for Women)
- Guidance for Gender-Lens Marketing of Green Finance Products in Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling Financial Institutions to Mainstream Gender-Smart Solutions in Their Green Finance Operations (Inter-American Development Bank)

Box 3: Example in practice: Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania Lulu Account

Lulu account from Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania

Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania targets customers in lower and middle-income brackets and is a bank of choice for MSMEs. The bank provides borrowing and savings products and strives to build long-term relationships with its clients. Access Microfinance is an agrolender, supporting farmers with inputs supply, labour payments and farm equipment.

Access Microfinance determined that women clients were reliable, trustworthy and overall a very good market segment to invest in. The bank wanted to promote women in business, and in 2018 launched the Lulu account – a value proposition specifically for women. Some features of the Lulu account include reduced loan processing times and reduced credit risk through insurance and business coaching.

Gender-lens marketing

To help reach target customers for the Lulu product, Access Microfinance engaged existing women clients in the delivery of their marketing messages. As most target customers were in rural areas, women's forums were conducted in towns such as Mwanza and Mbeya in addition to Dar es Salaam.

Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania

SOURCE: **Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania**. n.d. *Access Microfinance Bank Tanzania*. Cited 21 May 2024. https://www.accessmfb.co.tz/lulu/

Figure 8: Sample overview for getting started with gender-lens marketing

To get started on this journey, FSPs must first identify where they are. They can build credibility and insulate themselves from bad publicity by deepening their understanding of the organization's current approach to gender in marketing. The good news is that most brands do make mistakes when it comes to gender stereotypes in marketing and advertising-so identifying them poses low risk and high potential returns.

Audit Advertising Assets for Representation:

Many companies believe that their ads demonstrate gender equity, and yet when they quantitatively evaluate if women are being portrayed at the same rate as men, they find gaps. For instance, the Geena Davis Institute on Gender in Media analyzed millions of YouTube ads between 2015 and 2019 and found that female characters were included in only 38 percent of financial sector ads-one of the lowest levels across all sectors analyzed.

Assess Gender Portrayals in Advertising:

Similarly, FSPs can assess how men and women are portrayed in the ads for their marketing campaigns: Are women portrayed in realistic and unstereotyped roles? How often are they portrayed in professional and leadership positions? Conversely, how often are men doing household work? And, is the campaign accurately sub-segmenting women to reach them with relevant messaging for their different life-cycle stages?

Uncover Unintended Biases in the Marketing Mix:

In addition to what the ad campaign is communicating, FSPs need to look for unintentional biases in how they're reaching their audiences across different channels in their marketing mix. For instance, Alliance members have found that nontraditional channels such as on-the-ground networking events are particularly effective for reaching women. Uncovering biases is also important for social media advertising, as "attribute" and "look-a-like" targeting can easily skew the reach of advertising toward certain demographics while excluding others.

Build Diverse Teams

It's important for FSPs to ensure gender diversity in both in-house marketing teams and marketing agencies they hire. Diverse teams are widely recognized to have a number of business benefits, including improved innovation, the ability to create better solutions for women, and a possible increase in brand value. Alliance members also report the importance of engaging with gender-diverse marketing agencies to ensure these benefits translate throughout the marketing process.

Leverage Research

All too often, FSPs take a superficial marketing approach for women-targeted products when they should be building a holistic customer value proposition (CVP) and approach based on market research. Alliance members find that marketing to women with a concrete CVP that genuinely speaks to their specific concerns is the most effective way to reach female audiences and they've found that market research plays a crucial role in helping them do this.

SOURCE: Financial Alliance for Women. 2020. *InBrief: Gender Lens Marketing: Driving lasting change by championing women.* New York. https://financialallianceforwomen.org/download/inbrief-gender-lens-marketing/https://financialallianceforwomen.org/download/inbrief-gender-lens-marketing/

6. Partner selection tool

Objective: To help financial institutions to evaluate the gender inclusivity of potential partners.
As a financial institution advances on its gender inclusivity journey, it is important to work with partners with a similar commitment to avoid bringing their brand into potential disrepute.

Key considerations

1. Service offerings: Do the potential partner's product(s) address a gender gap for women in agricultural value chains?
2. Gender inclusivity: What is the current status of the potential partner in relation to gender inclusivity?
3. Gender strategy: Does the potential partner have a current gender strategy?
4. Commitment to gender inclusivity: Is the potential partner willing to adopt a gender strategy?
5. Gender key performance indicators: Does the potential partner track gender performance and use this for decision-making?

Tip

This tool is included here in the context of outreach partners but can also be used to evaluate partners across the spectrum of areas covered in this toolkit.

Resources

- Partner selection tool in Gender Transformative Toolkit (Mercy Corps AgriFin)
- The gender-responsive Business Model Canvas: A tool to assess agricultural service provision from a gender perspective (FAO)

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Monitoring and reporting

1. Gender monitoring and evaluation framework

Objective: To help financial institutions to develop and implement a monitoring and evaluation (M&E) framework.

Key considerations

1. Develop a theory of change that sets out pathways for change in knowledge, attitudes and behaviours related to gender inclusivity.
2. Design M&E questions based on the objectives of the gender inclusivity strategy.
3. Design the evaluation approach that will be used to measure and analyse the results.
4. Design indicators to track progress.
5. Develop M&E tools.

Resources

- RESPECT Framework Monitoring and Evaluation (UN Women)
- Gender Indicators Template (Annex 5)

2. Gender performance indicators

Objective: To help develop gender inclusivity key performance indicators.

Sample gender indicators

Internal environment

- Percentage of total revenues attributable to women's portfolio
- Percentage of women board members, executive, management and operative staff
- Women staff promotion rate
- Women staff retention rate
- Women served as a percentage of the market

Resources

- Gender Performance Indicators 2.0 (Women's World Banking)

Financial products and outreach

- Women borrowers/savers as a percentage of total borrowers/savers
- New women borrowers/savers as a percentage of total new borrowers/savers
- Women's savings accounts/accounts as a percentage of total accounts/savings accounts
- Percentage of women clients below a defined demographic (e.g. income)
- Percentage of women accessing two or more financial products
- Percentage of women reached through market research
- Women loan portfolio as a percentage of total loan portfolio
- Women average loan balance
- Women portfolio at risk as a percentage of total portfolio
- Borrower retention rate, by gender
- Average savings account balance, by gender
- Average transaction amount (deposits/ withdrawals), by gender
- Client satisfaction score, by gender
- Percentage of clients with inquiries or complaints, by gender
- Percentage of women clients who attend non-financial services


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3. Gender-disaggregated data guidance

Objective: To help financial institutions understand how it may be currently serving women (across internal environment, financial products and outreach); help identify gaps where operations can be improved and track progress against gender indicators.

Key considerations

1. Define questions for gender-disaggregated data based on what you want to know about women compared to men.
2. Define indicators to be measured. These should be specific, measurable, achievable, realistic and timebound.
3. Identify sources for data collection.
4. Adapt data collection systems to allow for gender data capture.
5. Introduce new gender-disaggregated data collection systems to the workforce.

Note

Data should be analysed to derive insights that should be used to improve gender inclusivity across the institution.

Resources

- Sex-Disaggregated Guidance Note in Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling Financial Institutions to Mainstream Gender-Smart Solutions in Their Green Finance Operations (Inter-American Development Bank)

Additional resources

- Sex-disaggregated data collection and analysis guides in Gender Transformative Toolkit (Mercy Corps AgriFin)

Figure 9: Sample guiding questions for financial institutions on sex-disaggregated data collection and analysis

1. **Define your questions.** *
2. Based on the questions you have now set, **define the metrics desired.** Be sure to set time for designing metrics that are not only feasible to collect, but also meaningful and relevant for decision making. *
3. **Review any existing customer databases and any disaggregation by sex.** As part of this, identify what data is currently tracked as well as where there are gaps in measurement and why.
4. **Identify if you have sufficient data to conduct a gender analysis of data.**
   - If Yes, skip to point 9.
   - If No, continue to point 5.
5. **Identify the data gaps** to be able to calculate the metrics desired.
6. **Identify the sources needed to fill these data gaps.** *
7. **Identify the system adaptations necessary** to ensure the automation of data extraction on a regular basis. *
8. **Introduce a new sex-disaggregated data collection and analysis system.** *
9. **Conduct a gender analysis of your data.** *
10. **Use your new sex-disaggregated data insights!** Go after newly- identified opportunities, design new products, services, and customer experiences or adapt existing ones, or re-shape your communications, to name a few. Be sure to incorporate this new sex-disaggregated data into dashboards to measure progress and iterate business strategy. *

SOURCE: IDB. 2022. *Gender-Smart Green Financing Toolkit: Enabling financial institutions to mainstream gender-smart solutions in their green finance operations.* Washington, D.C.

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Glossary of key terms

bank	A traditional commercial institution providing financial services such as transactions, credit, insurance and investment services.
digital financial services	Financial services delivered through a digital channel such as an online platform or mobile money.
gender	Socially constructed attributes and opportunities associated with being male and female. It has to do with how our society defines masculinity and femininity in terms of what is appropriate behaviour for men and women. Both men and women play a crucial role in the social construction of gender.
gender equality	The equal enjoyment by women, girls, boys and men of rights, opportunities, resources and rewards. Equality does not mean that women and men are the same but that their enjoyment of rights, opportunities and life changes are not governed or limited by whether they were born female or male.
gender policy	An intention expressed by an institution about how it seeks to address gender gaps across its organization.
gender inclusivity	Practices, policies and behaviours that ensure people of all gender identities feel respected, valued and included. It goes beyond merely recognizing gender diversity to actively creating an environment where individuals, regardless of their gender identity or expression, can participate fully and equally.
informal enterprise	An enterprise that is not constituted as a separate legal entity independently of its owner, and for which no complete accounts are available that would permit a financial separation of the production activities of the enterprise from the other activities of its owner(s). (ISO: IWA 34:2021, 3.14)
microfinance institution	A banking institution providing financial services to low-income individuals who are usually not served by traditional banks.
savings and credit cooperative	An autonomous association of persons united voluntarily to meet their common economic and social needs through a jointly owned and democratically controlled enterprise. (International Labour Organization Promotion of Cooperatives Recommendation, 2002 [No. 193])
theory of change	A theory of change is a method that explains how a given intervention, or a set of interventions, are expected to lead to a specific change. It illustrates the series of assumptions and links underpinning the presumed causal relationships between inputs, outputs, outcomes and impacts at various levels.
women-owned business	A business that is more than 50 percent owned by one or more women, whose management and control lie with one or more women. (ISO: IWA 34:2021, 3.1)
women-led business	A business that is at least 25 percent owned by one or more women, whose management and control lie with one or more women, which has at least one third of the board of directors comprised of women, where a board exists. (ISO: IWA 34:2021, 3.2)

Annex 1: Gender action plan template

ACTIVITY	TASKS	DUE DATE	STATUS	RESPONSIBLE PERSON
			[Not started, In progress, Pending, or Completed]	

SOURCE: Devised by author.

NOTE: This template is for guidance only. Ideally a Gender Action Plan should be integrated into a suitable project management tool).

Annex 2: Business Model Canvas template

Gender-responsive Business Model Canvas: Guiding questions

KEY PARTNERS	KEY ACTIVITIES	VALUE PROPOSITIONS	CUSTOMER RELATIONSHIPS	CUSTOMER SEGMENTS
	KEY RESOURCES	IMPACT	CHANNELS	

COST STRUCTURE	REVENUE STREAMS

SOURCE: FAO. 2023c. *The gender-responsive Business Model Canvas. A tool to assess agricultural service provision from a gender perspective.* Cairo.

Annex 3: Business Model Canvas with guiding questions

Gender-responsive Business Model Canvas: Guiding questions

KEY PARTNERS

- Who are the key partners of the service provider? And the key suppliers?
- Are these partners available and accessible to female entrepreneurs?
- How do these partners add to the value proposition?
- Are women involved in the service delivery model as entrepreneurs or employees?

KEY ACTIVITIES

- What are the main activities that the value proposition requires?
- What kind of activities do the 'customer relationships' channel and the 'revenue streams' require?
- And what key activities are needed for the provider to operate in a gender-responsive manner?
- Are the activities manageable for women entrepreneurs?

VALUE PROPOSITIONS

- What bundle of services are offered to and by women?
- Which relevant problem that women face in their role/ position in the value chain does the service (provider) address?
- How does the service respond to women's needs?

CUSTOMER RELATIONSHIPS

- What type of relationship does the business have with female and male customers?
- Is information about the service available and tailored to women (e.g. language, images used?)
- How does the service provider obtain information about female clients' needs?

CUSTOMER SEGMENTS

- Who is the business targeting (does it also specifically target women)?
- Is the business creating value for women equally as for men?
- What are the specific characteristics of the women and men targeted (e.g. age, socio-economic status, ethnicity, religious affiliation, marital status, (dis)ability, location, etc.)?

KEY RESOURCES

- What key resources does the provider need to have a successful business and deliver the service (physical, intellectual, human, financial)?
- Are these resources available, accessible and affordable for women entrepreneurs?
- Are your physical resources accessible to both women and men? (e.g. tools, equipment, technology etc.)
- Do men and women make equal use of training, learning and career advancement opportunities?
- Do men and women receive equal pay for equal work?

IMPACT

- Do the services have the potential to overcome or transform unequal social and gender norms?
- Does the service provider model create opportunities for women's entrepreneurship and/ or employment?

CHANNELS

- How does the business communicate and interact with its male and female customers?
- How available and responsive are these channels to female customers (e.g. presence of female extension workers, sales agents)?
- How does the business collect and integrate feedback from its male and female customers?
- Does the brand communicate gender equality principles?

COST STRUCTURE

- What are the costs the provider faces to deliver the value proposition? What is the cost for those engaged in the model as entrepreneurs? Are these costs affordable for female entrepreneurs?
- What is the price of the service for the end user? Can services be bundled together to reduce costs?

REVENUE STREAMS

- How are the customers paying for the service? Are there payment arrangements (e.g. instalments, on credit)
- Is the service affordable for women considering their purchasing power?
- What are the different revenue streams for the provider?
- Is the service financially viable?

SOURCE: FAO. 2023c. *The gender-responsive Business Model Canvas. A tool to assess agricultural service provision from a gender perspective.* Cairo.

Annex 4: Gender segmentation worksheet

GENDER SEGMENT	KEY ACTIVITY	KEY DEMOGRAPHICS (AGE, EDUCATION, INCOME, GEOGRAPHY)	FINANCIAL LITERACY AND BEHAVIOUR	FINANCIAL NEEDS	PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT OPPORTUNITY	RISKS AND MITIGATION MEASURES
Producer						
Processor						
Trader						
Agri business						

SOURCE: Devised by author.
NOTE: This template is for guidance only and may be adapted as needed.

Annex 5: Gender indicators template

OBJECTIVES	INDICATOR(S)	BASELINE	TARGETS	MEANS OF VERIFICATION	RISKS AND ASSUMPTIONS
Impact:					
Outcome 1					
Output 1					
Outcome 2					

SOURCE: Devised by author.

FAO Regional Office for Africa
raf-gender@fao.org

www.fao.org/africa

Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
Accra, Ghana

International Trade Centre
Women, Youth and Vulnerable Communities Section
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